



GST SINGES ESSENTIALS

WITH THE GST COUNCIL revising rates to rationalise the structure and increase tax revenues, prices of several daily-use items will go up. The 5 per cent tax on packaged kitchen commodities is set to make wheat flour, pulses, cereals, puffed rice and curd dearer, while an increase in rate from 12 per cent to 18 per cent on

LED lamps, lights & fixtures will lead to a price increase of 5-6 per cent. With a 12 per cent tax on hotel rooms that cost less than ₹1,000 per night, tourism is set to be hit, while a 5 per cent tax on non-ICU hospital rooms that cost ₹5,000 per day will make healthcare dearer.

—ARNAB DUTTA

CHINESE CHECKERS

The Delhi High Court has allowed Chinese smartphone maker vivo to operate its bank accounts that were frozen by the Enforcement Directorate (ED)—the company has to maintain a balance of ₹250 crore at all times. The ED had raided vivo's operations in 44 locations under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act—it said the firm had remitted about ₹62,476 crore of its turnover to China between 2017 and 2021 to avoid paying taxes in India. A couple of months earlier, the ED had seized ₹5,571 crore from Xiaomi India, another Chinese smartphone giant.

—NIDHI SINGAL

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DRY RUN ENDS

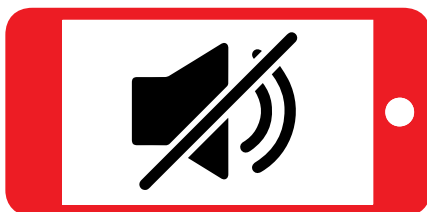
With the three-month ban on new fund offers (NFOs) coming to an end, mutual fund houses are lining up new schemes to garner investor money. WhiteOak Capital Mutual Fund is set to launch its maiden equity scheme—an actively-managed flexi-cap fund, while Motilal Oswal AMC will have a passive scheme for the financial services sector, excluding banks. Will investors bite in these volatile times?

—ASHISH RUKHAIYAR



5.9

**PER CENT
GROSS NPAs
REPORTED BY
SCHEDULED
COMMERCIAL
BANKS AS OF
MARCH 2022; A
SIX-YEAR LOW,
ACCORDING TO
THE RBI'S LATEST
FINANCIAL
STABILITY
REPORT**



DIGITAL SHACKLES

Exempted from the Registration of Books Act, 1867 for long, digital news media might be regulated soon if the government's draft Registration of Press and Periodicals Bill, 2019, is passed by Parliament. Here, digital news media is defined as "news in digitised format that can be transmitted over the internet, computer or mobile networks and includes text, audio, video and graphics". Digital media could face action for "violations" under the Act, if passed.

—NIDHI SINGAL

Muscling up on Trade

THE BOARD OF TRADE, which is mandated to advise the government on policy measures to improve India's foreign trade, will see some 29 non-official members from large and small enterprises and different sectors, including names like Rajesh Gopinathan, CEO & MD of TCS, and KKR India Chairman Sanjay Nayar. Given the uncertain global geopolitical situation, and India's burgeoning trade complexity as well as trade deficit, this is a much needed move.

—RAJAT MISHRA